

VIEWPOINT | S. PRASANNARAJAN

Patil Rap

Greatness is being thrust upon an honourable old lady from Jalgaon, and let us take comfort from the dismal fact that her political benefactors excel in dishing out such favours to family loyalists with veiled talents. It took a Jayalalithaa to tell the unedited truth: Congress has played “a joke on the nation” by putting up a dusted-off Pratibha Patil as the presidential candidate—and Amma knows a few things about jokes. Seasoned panegyrists at the Court of Her Majesty Sonia Gandhi and sundry symbol-seekers and pattern-fetishists in the media are bound to come out with a host of self-deluding explanations. A Sikh prime minister, a Roman Catholic widow of foreign origin as the most powerful political arbiter, and a woman as the head of the republic. Wow! Diversity could not have been more unifying. Or: Look at how Mrs Patil has overtaken Mrs Clinton. And please spare us the pain of sociology: gender empowerment and the ascent of the female Gandhian. Reality is less appealing.

Aren't you getting intimations of the Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed moment already? He, the obedient one, asked no question, raised no eyebrow, while signing the declaration of the Emergency on the midnight of June 25, 1975. He chose to be the loyal servant of Indira Gandhi, not of the Constitution. Today, Sonia looks only slightly better than the Roman emperor who made his horse a senator. She could have been different; this could have been yet another opportunity for Sonia who stunned the nation twice with her “moral” no to play smarter than her antagonists. Instead, she played the benevolent employer, and made the presidency the lucky governor's next posting. As banal as that. The apparatchiks of AKG Bhavan who earlier wanted a candidate with “political stature” are the collaborators in this selection. Now we know what they mean by “political” and “stature”.

Wish we had such a candidate supported by the ruling coalition as well. Political stature? Well, you don't have to look beyond the vice-president. Then Shekhawat is not a Muslim, a scheduled caste or a woman. Neither a token nor a symbol, he is a former patriarch of the BJP, and his conduct as veep has been certified as exemplary by almost all parties. Ah, “political” clashes with “stature” here. So he has been ticked no. All right, you have a national treasure in the Rashtrapati Bhavan. Caste is perfect, stature is high, and the performance has been superb as India's first “people's president”. Periodically, his so-called political naivete, though, has been found rather troubling by the Government—more specifically, the Congress. (The most ideal Manmohan Singh is already employed.) There were indeed more qualified choices than Patil but small-minded politics prevailed. The office of the president, largely ceremonious during normal times, is only as good as the person who occupies it. Congress had the maximum chances to choose the president, and more often than not, its choices were not influenced by the mind of the candidate. They were not exactly the successors of Dr Radhakrishnan. Sounds too idealistic? Yes, when you realise that the firm of Sonia is not exactly the party of Nehru.



Even during Giani Zail Singh's election in 1982, the Akali Dal had supported the Congress candidate because he belonged to Punjab.

However, the UPA knows that while it has a combination of winning cards, it is still not in possession of the ace. Presidential elections take place via secret ballot and parties are dissuaded from issuing whips that ensure that its MPs and MLAs do not stray from the official line. There is no guarantee that all the UPA allies will vote for the official candidate. Shekhawat proved that during the last vice-presidential elections when he polled 79 votes above the NDA's total. The Congress leadership is aware that there is considerable dismay in the party over its choice of candidate. There is also some resentment in the party that its president had to settle for someone who was not even on the

PATIL'S CANDIDATURE BEGAN WITH A CONTROVERSY SHE CREATED WITH HER COMMENTS ON THE PURDAH SYSTEM.

initial shortlist of candidates, not to mention embarrassing at least three cabinet ministers—all under pressure from the Left allies. Sonia has deputed trusted aides like Ahmad Patel, Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi and Suresh Pachouri to deal with unhappy allies while Patil paid personal visits to disgruntled Congressmen such as Arjun Singh and Karan Singh, and UPA allies, RJD chief Lalu Prasad and Pawar.

The NDA reckons that if Kalam were to contest as a joint opposition candidate, the numbers could well swing in his favour given his popular appeal and the fact that the UPA-Left candidate lacks any claims to be the next occupant of Rashtrapati Bhavan. Opposition sources say that if Kalam finally throws his hat into the ring, then Shekhawat, who is now listed as independent, will withdraw in favour of the incumbent and will in turn be accom-